cholera.[15] Travancore was as badly affected as anywhere, while the abuses of caste and the widespread use of the outcaste *avarna*s as slave labour, generally known as *oozhiyam vala* or 'labour without pay', continued almost unabated. The granting of rights to Nadar and Channar women converts to wear the *kuppayam* blouse created tensions which degenerated into increasingly violent confrontations provoked by gangs of higher-caste men assaulting women whom they considered to be exceeding their status by dressing up or wearing jewellery inappropriately. This culminated in a series of affrays in several regions of Travancore in 1858, the so-called Channar Revolt, that prompted the then Governor of the Madras Presidency Sir Charles Trevelyan to intervene, leading to the issue on 26 July 1859 of a royal proclamation granting every woman in the kingdom of Travancore the right to cover her breasts and wear such jewellery as she chose.

But that was by no means the end of it. Writing to a friend in 1860, the wife of a Christian missionary reported that 'A Nair can approach but not touch a Namboodiri Brahmin: a Chovan [Ezhava] must remain thirty-six paces off, and a Pulayan slave ninety-six steps distant. A Chovan must remain twelve steps away from a Nair, and a Pulayan sixty-six steps off, and a Parayan some distance farther still. A Syrian Christian may touch a Nair (though this is not allowed in some parts of the country) but the latter may not eat with each other. Pulayans and Parayars, who are the lowest of all, can approach but not touch, much less may they eat with each other.'[16]

Given the source of that statement, we should allow for exaggeration and bias. It was written at a time when a fierce ideological struggle was taking place for the souls of the Keralans, which would end in Kerala becoming the most religiously mixed, the most literate and arguably the most tolerant state in India – a quite extraordinary turn-around